throne in 1591 and re-styled himself Sultan Burhan Nizam Shah II but then resisted all efforts by Mughal ambassadors, including Faizi, to submit to Akbar, allowing Abu'l Fazl the opportunity of an irritated rant against him:

> When Burhan al-Mulk prevailed over Ahmadnagar, he should have increased his devotion and gratitude, and been an example of obedience to other rulers in that quarter. The wine of success robbed him of his sense, and he forgot the varied favours he had received from the Shahinshah.

Fortuitously for the Mughals, Burhan Shah died in 1595, leading to a fractious and unstable environment, which Akbar was now ready to exploit. He directed Mirza Murad to proceed from Gujarat to Ahmadnagar. En route to Ahmadnagar Murad met some Jesuit priests at Surat, heading in the opposite direction. This was the third Jesuit mission summoned by Akbar. The mission included three handpicked Jesuits and was headed by Father Jerome Xavier, an older man and a grandnephew of Saint Francis, a man of 'enthusiastic asceticism' who would spend twenty-three years at the Mughal court 'sometimes in favour, sometimes in prison'. There was also Father Emmanuel Pignero, and a coadjutor* called Benoist Goes who had 'lived a somewhat dissipated life' and joined the mission 'in consequence of some youthful escapade'.

Murad summoned the Jesuits to his travelling camp where he received them in impressive state in his grand war tent, reclining on a takht. All his attendants, wrote the Jesuits, 'were standing as silent as statues with their eyes fixed on him'. Murad was gracious and informal with the three men and asked them 'if there was snow or ice in Portugal, and whether bears, hares and other wild animals were to be found there, or birds of the chase, such as falcons and hawks'. Satisfied with the answers he received, the twenty-five-year-old mirza insisted the Jesuits accept some money and then mounted an elephant, from which he jumped onto a much larger one, 'which seemed like a tower'. He was accompanied by 4,000–5,000 horsemen, 400 elephants, 40 dromedaries, 4,000 bullocks and 15 large pieces of cannon. 'He went to this war,' agreed the Jesuits, 'with good courage, and with great hopes of gaining possession of the kingdom of the Deccan. But as he was as yet inexperienced, and as he allowed himself to be guided by the young, paying no attention to the counsels of his elders, his actions were not of the wisest.' They went on to write that though 'by